

Handout - Terence Parsons, “Referring to Nonexistent Objects”

Framing the Problem and the Proposed Solution

The problem: Ordinary language appears to let us *refer* to things that do not exist—fictional characters (Sherlock Holmes), mythological entities (Pegasus, Zeus), dream objects (the unicorn I dreamed about), and even impossible objects (the round square). Yet much of twentieth-century analytic philosophy (Russell, Quine, early Wittgenstein) insists that *there are no such objects*, and that apparent reference to them must be explained away as either (i) failure of reference or (ii) misleading surface grammar that hides a different logical form.

Parsons’s central claim: *Referring to a nonexistent object is not the same thing as failing to refer at all.* Our linguistic practices distinguish these cases, and philosophical theories should respect that distinction rather than eliminate it.

The solution: Parsons develops a **quasi-Meinongian theory** of objects, according to which:

- Some objects **exist**.
- Some objects **do not exist**, but are nevertheless objects with properties.
- Some singular terms **fail to refer altogether**.

He supplements this ontology with a carefully structured semantics for predicates, quantifiers, definite descriptions, and proper names, showing how reference to nonexistent objects can be coherent without contradiction.

Part I: Referring to Nonexistent Objects ≠ Failing to Refer (pp. 36–37)

Parsons begins with **linguistic data**, not metaphysical speculation.

Two contrasting conversational cases

Case 1: Failure of reference

- Speaker says: “*The man in the doorway looks silly.*”

- It turns out: *There is no man in the doorway.*
- Speaker retracts and treats further questions as **spurious**.

👉 **Diagnosis:** The speaker *tried* to refer but failed. Once the mistake is recognized, there is no object to talk about.

Case 2: Reference to a nonexistent object

- Speaker says: *"The unicorn I dreamed about looked silly."*
- Listener objects: *"There are no unicorns."*
- Speaker replies: *"So what? It was a unicorn I dreamed about."*

👉 **Diagnosis:** The speaker **continues to answer questions** about the unicorn (what it looked like, whom it resembled). The discourse remains perfectly intelligible.

Philosophical significance

- Ordinary speakers clearly distinguish:
 - **No object at all** (mistaken perception)
 - **An object that does not exist** (fictional, dreamt, mythical)
- Attempts to paraphrase away apparent reference to nonexistent objects (via Russellian descriptions, etc.) have **not succeeded**, despite decades of effort.

Conclusion of Part I: We should take our linguistic practices at face value and allow that we sometimes *genuinely refer* to nonexistent objects (pp. 36–37).

Part II: A Quasi-Meinongian Theory of Objects (pp. 37–40)

Parsons adapts ideas from **Alexius Meinong**, while modifying them to avoid well-known problems.

Core idea: Objects and sets of properties

Principle 1:

- No two *existing* objects have exactly the same properties.

Principle 2:

- For any set of nuclear properties, there is exactly one object that has exactly that set .

From this, Parsons proposes a general schema:

- To **each non-empty set of properties**, there corresponds **exactly one object**.

Example:

- The set {goldenness, mountainhood} corresponds to **the gold mountain**.
- Since no such mountain exists, this object is **nonexistent**, but still an object.

Nuclear vs. extranuclear properties (crucial distinction)

Nuclear properties

- Ordinary descriptive properties
- Examples: *is golden*, *is a mountain*, *is tall*, *kicked Socrates*

Extranuclear properties

- Do **not** determine the object's identity
- Examples:
 - Ontological: *exists*, *is fictional*, *is mythical*
 - Modal: *is possible*, *is impossible*
 - Intentional: *is thought about by Meinong*
 - Technical: *is complete*



Why this matters:

- If *existence* were nuclear, there would be an **existent gold mountain**, which is absurd.
- Therefore, *exists* must be extranuclear.

Completeness, incompleteness, and indeterminacy

- An object is **complete** iff for every nuclear property F, it either has F or its *negation*.
- Many nonexistent objects are **incomplete**.

Example:

- The gold mountain:
 - Has *goldenness* and *mountainhood*
 - Neither has *blueness* nor *non-blueness*
 - → **Indeterminate** with respect to blueness (pp. 38–39)

Possible vs. impossible objects

- **Possible object:** It is possible that some existing object could have all its nuclear properties.
- **Impossible object:** No such existing object could exist.

Examples:

- Possible nonexistent object: *the gold mountain*
- Impossible object: *the round square* (roundness + squareness)

Key payoff: Parsons can explain reference to fictional, mythical, and even impossible objects *without contradiction*.

Part III: Singular Terms and Logical Notation (pp. 40–43)

Parsons introduces a **formal language** resembling the predicate calculus to regiment reference.

Objects and predicates

- Object variables/names: a, b, c, x, y
- Nuclear predicates: P^N, Q^N
- Extranuclear predicates: P^E, Q^E

Example:

- Let D^Nx = “x is a detective”
- Let E^Ex = “x exists”
- Let s = Sherlock Holmes

Then:

- D^Ns is **true**
- E^Es is **false**

👉 Holmes is a detective who does not exist (p. 41).

Quantifiers

- Quantifiers range over **all objects**, not just existing ones.

Example:

- $\exists x(D^Nx \wedge E^Ex)$: Some detectives exist

- $\exists x(D^Nx \wedge \neg EEx)$: Some detectives do not exist

Definite descriptions

Notation:

- $(ix)\Phi$ = “the x such that Φ ”

Semantics:

- If exactly one object satisfies Φ , the description refers.
- Otherwise, it **fails to refer**.

Key distinction:

- $(ix)(winged \wedge horse)$ refers to **Pegasus** (nonexistent but real object).
- $(ix)(existing \wedge man-in-doorway)$ may fail to refer altogether.

If a description fails to refer, sentences containing it are **untrue** (whether false or truth-valueless is left open).

Proper names

Parsons argues against several orthodox views:

- Names like “*Pegasus*” and “*Sherlock Holmes*” **do refer**—to nonexistent objects.
 - Reference does **not** require a causal chain ending in an existing object.
 - Proper names can still have **sense** and support **de re / de dicto** distinctions.
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